



trick Rama (a manifestation of the god Vishnu). Magic in the Hindu world became connected with *maya*, a concept originally meaning power or wisdom, but later embodying illusion—the gap between human perception and the ever-changing, unstable material world.

Magical texts

Just like their counterparts in other belief systems, many Hindus sought direct means to achieve divine intervention. The *Atharvaveda*, composed around 1200–1000 BCE, contains 730 hymns and 6,000 mantras attributed to the sages Atharvan (who authored some core hymns), Angiras, and Bhṛigu.

As well as containing hymns to secure long life, heal wounds, fight off devils, or procure a marriage partner, the *Atharvaveda* refers to amulets, suggesting that their use

IN CONTEXT

Magic as entertainment

In the 20th century, India developed a reputation as a cradle of magical performance, and illusionists such as P.C. Sorcar, Sr., and Vazhakunnam (dubbed the “Father of Magic”) became especially popular. Among their signature turns was the *Cheppum Panthum* (Cups and Balls trick, in which balls are made to randomly appear and disappear), and the Indian Rope Trick, in which the magician appears to climb a levitating length of rope. A version of the Indian Rope Trick was first described by the Arab traveler Ibn Battuta back in the 14th century.

Street magicians perform the Indian Rope Trick for an audience of British soldiers in the 1940s.



was widespread. The book mentions that one such amulet came from the splinters of 10 holy trees that could protect against demonic possession.

There were other more spectacular examples of magic—in the texts, if not in real life—with accounts of spiritually evolved *tantriks* (occultists), who used practices such as hypnosis to create illusions. The *Atharvaveda* gives reminders of older, possibly shamanic traditions, too, such as the use of *ojhas* (exorcists) and the worship of Agni, the god of fire, who was believed to purify the souls of the dead and take them from the pyre to be reborn.



◀ Divine protection

In this scene from the Hindu epic called the *Mahabharata*, Queen Draupadi, whose husband has lost her in a game of dice, is disrobed. However, the god Krishna protects the queen's honor by magically creating more layers of cloth as each length of her sari is unwound.